

Testimony of Donald Wittenberg for Oct. 20, 2021

My name is Donald Wittenberg. I have lived in NE Philadelphia since 1973. I have lived here consistently without interruption. During these years I have seen the population decrease in Philadelphia as well as have seen the number of congressional districts decrease. When I moved to Philadelphia in 1962 there were 4 congressional districts all within the city boundaries. It looks like the proposed changes will have Philadelphia with less than 2 districts. Part of the 2nd district will be moved into Bucks County. There are times when our representatives may have opposing community pressures. Bucks County may have needs which differ from NE Philadelphia. Our representative may be torn as to which part of the district to lend the balance of his/her voice.

During my adult life I have held one occupation, that of an educator in the Philadelphia School District. I was a teacher for 13 years than an Elementary School Principal for 18 years and finally a Central Office Administrator for 13 years. Nine of my years as a principal I served in the lower section of NE Philadelphia. While serving as a principal there I also participated in community events such as the Lawncrest Fourth of July Parade, maintained the school to be open for community sports, and, of course, had annual activities enjoyed by members of the community such as Winter and Spring Holiday Shows, 75th Anniversary celebration of our school (1916-1991), Halloween parades in the school yard, etc.

Before 1854 Philadelphia City consisted of a small area between the two rivers from Vine Street to South Street. All areas outside of this boundary were townships such as Germantown, Kensington, Oxford, Byberry, etc. By having Philadelphia City and Philadelphia County with one boundary. Then the Commonwealth of Pennsylvania created a unified governmental structure in SE Pennsylvania.

I believe that one of the goals of redistricting is to keep the districts compressed into districts that are as cohesive as possible. A flaw with the current plan of having the Second District flowing outside the city boundaries can easily be corrected by increasing the NE Philadelphia area so that less of Bucks county takes up part of the NE Philadelphia. I don't know the population data but it is possible that the Second District could contain all of the portions that are being considered for Bucks County and the Philadelphia boundary can be made whole.

The chipping away of the Philadelphia congressional boundary would have a deteriorating effect on Philadelphia to improve its destiny.